protocol referred to it as “another scenario”—proposed to declare the conflict a US-Cuban affair in which the USSR had no legal or military involvement. “In case of an attack, all the equipment is Cuban, and the Cubans declare that they will respond,” reads a record of the meeting.[8]

According to Mikoyan’s recollections, the author of that scenario was Marshal Malinovsky. “This idea appealed to Khrushchev,” remembered Mikoyan. He explained the reasons: “Of course at that point Kennedy’s appeal to the USSR [to remove the weapons] became senseless.… Negotiations should have been conducted with Cuba, but we were no longer [an] interested [party]. All the while the risk of a nuclear strike against the Soviet Union was supposedly lessened.” Mikoyan considered that logic superficial. In his own words, he “took the floor and resolutely objected.” In his mind the Americans had already accustomed themselves to the idea that the USSR had nuclear weapons, but nuclear weapons capable of striking the United States in Fidel Castro’s hands were another matter altogether. He predicted that the Americans would “panic and immediately come down on Cuba with all of their might. There would be nothing left of the people, island, our troops. Our efforts would be nothing more than a cruel joke.”[9]

Mikoyan managed to get Khrushchev and other members of the Presidium on his side. The idea of publishing the agreement on mutual military assistance between Cuba and the USSR would ultimately be rejected as well. What they agreed on was putting the Soviet troops in Cuba on full alert. “First and foremost, we decided to task Malinovsky with ordering the commander of our forces in Cuba, General Pavlov [Pliev], to prepare for defense of Cuba with military action in the event of an American invasion, and if that failed, to use the intermediate-range missiles,” recalled Mikoyan. They were ready to use strategic nuclear weapons. Malinovsky prepared a draft telegram to Pliev saying exactly that: “[A]ll means at Pavlov’s disposal should be in a state of readiness.” It then suddenly dawned on Khrushchev that they were giving Pliev authorization to use the ballistic missiles. “If all means without reservations, that means missiles too, that is, the outbreak of thermonuclear war,” said Khrushchev. “How can that be possible?” It was a faux pas on the part of Malinovsky, and Mikoyan did not fail to record it in his recollections as a case of